

To whom it may Concern:

This was my first year at Vista as a Middle School Math Teacher. I specifically sought out Vista because I wanted my children to go there. My daughter has always struggled in school and for years I had heard so many wonderful things about Vista being a welcoming place that put the needs of students above everything else. Unfortunately, my experience with Vista under the direction of the new School Director was the opposite of putting children first. Instead, it was a culture of control, manipulation, secrecy, the bottom line of finances, and totalitarianism. The new director created this hostile work environment by bullying, intimidation, and pitting staff and teachers against each other.

In his introductory speech to staff, the School Director almost immediately told the entire staff that Vista's academics were poor and hurting. In the many speeches I have heard the School Director give, he constantly speaks of culture code and collective teacher efficacy. From the beginning he laid the foundation that the staff should know the academic classes and teachers are a stain upon the school. This became the consensus started from our leader that us academics, specifically math teachers, are the embarrassment of the school. I had another teacher tell me recently they noticed how in almost every meeting the School Director would talk about how bad our math department is, and even at the Christmas Party it was thrown into his speech. With this as my first year here at Vista, this was what I walked into. The School Director's foundation of collective teacher efficacy is that we should all believe that our department is already a failure before we begin.

This belief was widespread as my students did not want to be in my class, and I understand that. From the beginning I was told from students that this subject doesn't matter, how they were here for robotics, dance, art, theater ect. The students were being forced to be in my class. I feel much of my job as an educator is to create a safe space where students feel comfortable, confident, and engaged in learning about math; however, this was so much more difficult when the belief in math is a necessary evil. I know that students do not come to Vista for math; however, it is a vital part of their education, and we needed support from our leadership. This attitude towards math led to lack of engagement and major behavior issues.

My teaching philosophy is that every single child can learn and be proficient in math, just not the same way on the same day. Each child is an individual and it takes differentiation, patience, and understanding to make sure that each student's needs are met. There is no cookie cutter curriculum or teaching standard that can reach each student in the way they need it, and the curriculum that Vista had chosen before I started was not working for the students that I had. When I was speaking to the other math teachers, they were having the same problems with engagement, behavior, prior knowledge recollection, retainment, and test scores. The other 7th grade teacher, Kalynn Snow, was having the most success with students. Kalynn is a brilliant teacher who has been teaching at Vista for 15 years and has been very successful with high test scores, student engagement, and a reputation for making math fun, memorable, and meaningful. We were working collectively to try and help our students, but needed more help so we brought it up to the administration. We had an emergency math meeting with the middle school math teachers, the School Director, and the Teaching Coach. I noticed every time Kalynn tried to speak, the School Director would just talk over her. Now my biggest issue was the behavior of

our students and needing more support from administration to change the perception and culture of wanting to be in math; however, Administration heard that we didn't know how to teach the curriculum and the teachers needed more training. The School Director showed and spoke about John Hattie's visible barometer of influence, something I'm very familiar with. At the top of the zone of desired effects is collective teacher efficacy, teacher credibility, and direct instruction. He said the reason the curriculum wasn't working was our fault as teachers and our lack of belief. More on why this is significant later.

I was told by the other Math teachers that they had brought concerns up before and had felt no one was listening to them, but the administration seemed to be more receptive and listening to me.

From that meeting in October until December, I watched my co-worker go from a confident veteran teacher to someone who was questioning herself constantly. This was heartbreaking to see. I believe she will be writing about her own experience also. This was my perspective from what I saw. Throughout this time, I was given observations from the Teaching Coach that were always complimentary. I was told by the Teaching Coach that I was engaging, and she could tell I really care about my students. Nowhere, at this time from the administration was I told I was teaching the curriculum incorrectly. I was also told by the administration that I could bring in supplementary materials and that I did not need to teach the curriculum with fidelity; however, as of late I have heard that the curriculum failed because we (teachers) didn't know what we were doing and was not teaching correctly with fidelity. There was so much inconsistency.

Mid December, I went to have lunch with Kalynn and she came into the room shaking and crying telling me that she had just quit. She told me that she could not be forced to be a different teacher than what she is. The students were devastated. I was devastated. I cried with her, I cried with the students.

At this time, the administration was very secretive about their meetings; contrary to what the School Director had said at the beginning of the year about full transparency. Apparently, it is ok to be fully transparent about test scores and shame the Language art teachers in front of the entire staff, but never transparent about his decisions. So much secrecy from this point on. I was told there were many meetings about me, but to this point there were no meetings with me. Finally, right before Christmas break, they brought me in, told me I was the future of their math department, and that someday if the curriculum still wasn't working, I would be helping choose a new one. It was a pleasant conversation, and I was hopeful. We talked about Kalynn's classes. They had interviewed a teacher and were going to hire him. They said they didn't want to disrupt my Academic Support classes. The next day I received a text message from the Teaching Coach telling me that the teacher they interviewed had turned down the job and that it looked like I would more than likely be taking over Kalynn's classes. I said I was willing to. That was the only communication I received during the break. I spent much of my Christmas Break familiarizing myself with the 6th grade curriculum and preparing for the rest of the year. Time I could have had with my own children, I spent in preparation.

I was given zero communication when I came back from break. I was prepared to take the classes and had heard nothing to the contrary. Teachers returned to school a day before the

students returned. After waiting in my room for two hours, I had to seek out the School Director to ask what I needed to do. He looked surprised at me and said they had decided to shake things up and go in a different direction. I was fine with this, I just felt like I had wasted my break and needed clear communication.

They hired a new teacher to take over Kalynn's classes teaching part time, and then to help Maree Berry part time in her classes. I immediately became friends with the new teacher and realized we needed to work together to get through the rest of the year. She had a very different teaching style than the students were used to. I had many conversations with her where she said she was told to teach this curriculum with absolute fidelity. She was thrown into a very difficult situation where students had lost a beloved teacher (Kalynn Snow) and were fighting against the curriculum. The lack of interest in the curriculum was not a new issue. It was one of the issues we (the math department) had brought up back in October. The new teacher was determined to teach the students this curriculum. I was staying late with her almost every night to go over the math. The students and parents started to fight against the new teacher being there. I was not privy to these emails; I was told by administration and the new teacher that they were constantly being berated with complaints. I was trying to do what I could to be supportive and helpful to the new teacher. We had so many meetings during this time. From one of these meetings Maree Berry recorded the School Director telling us that he knew our end of year test scores would be low this year and that he was looking at this as a beginning. He also said we would not be punished for low test scores.

We had scheduled a training session with the Carnegie rep. I was excited to watch him teach a lesson to observe and learn; hoping this would help me with my students. My first meeting with the rep was after school. I asked him about differentiating the curriculum, making sure I was covering the state standards, and how to stay on pace. He told me he was not ready for an in-depth conversation, and this was just introductory. He did tell me he didn't believe in teaching to standards, I said but that's what the students will be tested on at the end of the year, he responded that would take care of itself. I was told that he would be teaching my class so I could observe him; however, it was then made clear that he was there to observe me the next day. I didn't make it home until after 6 that night. The next day I was sent an email that they were changing my observation time. They were now going to come during my hardest class period. The lesson I felt went really well, but I was nervous and went through more material than I had planned on, I stumbled. Later that day, we had another training session with him. He told me I did some brilliant things and that I was a very engaging teacher. He asked me if I had prepared that lesson. I said no. I am an honest person so truth is, I didn't have much time, was expecting to observe him, and just glanced over the material. About 30 minutes later I received a text from the Teaching Coach that said, "Did you hear what Shala said!". I responded, at least I'm honest. She told me that was meant to be sent to the School Director, not me. We had a very heated conversation where she told me how disappointed she was in me. After I had spent my Christmas break preparing for classes I wasn't taking, after countless hours spent after school to help the teacher they hired because no one else was there to help her, and after changing the plan on me for observation, I was told I'm the disappointment. She was caught talking to the School Director about me in a very unprofessional, catty way. The Teaching Coach has apologized countless for this incident, and this is one of the only negative experiences I have had with her. In fact, I think she has tried to navigate the decisions and culture that the School Director has created. I

have heard her say several times to me how she is sorry. That this is not the Vista she knows and is used to. I have heard that from several teachers.

I started to have parents reach out to me and students asking if they could switch to my class instead of the new teacher's. I was conscious to stay very neutral and supportive of the New Teacher. When this happened, I would bring this up to the Teaching Coach.

I was brought into a meeting with the School Director, the Teaching Coach, and one of the Enrollment counselors. They told me that students were leaving in droves going to online math, and that means we are losing money. It came down to money, not the students. They said it wasn't working out and they should have had me take those classes coming back from Christmas Break. They asked me if I would consider taking over the New Teachers classes. The first thing I asked was if they had spoken to her. They said no. Believing this was best for students, I would do it. I cried, I knew this would be devastating for the New Teacher. I should have asked more questions.

They told me to just teach every class the same thing to make it easier on me. This goes completely against my teaching philosophy. Knowing I would now have two 8th grade classes, four 7th grade regular classes, a 7th grade honors class, and a 6th grade honors class I knew there was no way I could teach them all the same. This doubled my workload with very little compensation increase. I got to work on preparing for each of my classes. I spent so many hours at school and home preparing for each class. The School Director has mentioned several times that they tried to give me a prep. Their idea of a prep was 20-minute increments in classes where there was a Para-professional. The reason there is a Para in those classes is because those classes have students on I.E.P.s and need extra support, not for me to take a break. I did not feel comfortable with this so chose instead to work through lunch and afterschool. I asked if I could be relieved instead of Carpool duty, they agreed.

The week after I took over the classes was Parent Teacher Conferences. I was given no direction from the School Director, no support, in fact he left with the Business Manager and the Teaching Coach to go on a job fair trip. I was left to be interrogated by the new parents. It was grueling. I was asked my qualifications, about the curriculum, what happened with Kalynn Snow, and what Vista's plans were for the future. After I was emotionally, mentally, and physically tired. This is how I remained for the rest of the school year. When the administration came back, the School Director gave a speech about how fun and funny his trip with the Business Manager was. The School Director has never thanked me for my loyalty and for the way I navigated through this transition for students. I did hear from the Enrollment Counselor and the Teaching Coach that once I took over, the bombardment of complaints stopped, and some students came back from online. They did thank me. I believe that they truly have Vista's best interests at heart and too have been trying to navigate through all of the transitions

At the School Board Meeting. I was listening when the Carnegie representative said that the reason the curriculum wasn't working is that it was implemented incorrectly and that the teachers don't know what they are doing.

The School Director scheduled a time to observe each teacher and then a brief meeting after to discuss. Because I didn't ever want an incident again like I had with the Teaching Coach, I had been over preparing each lesson. We needed to submit our Success Criteria and learning target before hand, and I submitted the wrong lesson because I now had two weeks of lessons prepared beforehand! I realized the morning of the observation and wrote out the correct Success Criteria; I had it on my desk as well as on the board for my students to see. During my meeting with the School Director, he had typed out that I taught the wrong lesson. It also said that I gave a direct instruction lesson and that we were trying to get away from that at Vista. He had me sign this paper. I now realize this is so he can manipulate the narrative with paperwork. I told him how that is my next lesson and showed him the correct success criteria and asked if he had seen the one written on the board. He then told me how I am an extremely knowledgeable math teacher and that every single student in that classroom was engaged and writing. I then brought up John Hattie and Hattie's Barometer that the School Director was always referring to. School Director was excited and asked if I was starting to geek out on Hattie. I told him I have been familiar with this for a long time and pointed out to him that some of the top things that are in the desired zone effect are direct instruction and teacher credibility. I expressed that I didn't appreciate how teacher credibility was being taken away from us. I also expressed that my students don't all learn the same way and are on different levels. It is hard to have so many different levels in one classroom. He told me I need to learn how to ask a question of how to fix something instead of stating my opinion. I responded that I tried asking back in October and instead of helping they turned it into a war against the curriculum.

The curriculum was dropped very quickly after that conversation. I am not sure what made the Administration decide to change. When we found out, the New Teacher came into my classroom very upset. She had been moved to working as a Para in the elementary school. I said I was happy. The students were not receptive to this curriculum, and it wasn't working, it also wasn't covering all the Utah State Standards. The New Teacher said she was upset because she was told to teach this with fidelity, the students hated it, she was let go, and they ended up just dropping the curriculum. There were students in the room. One who asked me after the New Teacher left what she was doing in there! I said she's a coworker and a friend.

Friday, before Spring Break I was told to come meet in Dr. Blasko's office. I saw him in the hall before and he was extremely friendly. I asked him what this was about and he told me to just wait. We waited in his office saying random pleasantries with the H.R. Rep, before the Enrollment Counselor joined us. Right at the beginning the School Director told me that accusations had been made against me and that I needed to tell the truth. If it was found that I wasn't telling the truth, my job could be at stake and further action could be taken against me. He then asked me questions regarding anything I had ever said to the New Teacher. He also asked questions about ridiculous claims of me sending emails to students and parents of the New Teacher's students behind her back in hopes to sabotage her. After a while of this I broke down into an emotional state. I'm not even sure what I said at this point because my head was reeling, I was scared, and I was sobbing. The pressure from the extra-doubled workload, the constant assessing and changing to try and fit each students needs, and the lack of support from the administration finally hit me when my integrity was being put into question. I told them how the New Teacher was one of my only friends here and I felt she had been mistreated. The School Director eluded that the New Teacher was making all of these claims against me. The Enrollment

Counselor showed a lot of concern, and the H.R Rep. suggested if I needed therapy, that we have one included in our employee benefits. The School Director said 7 different times that he couldn't tell me what to do but would strongly recommend not discussing this with anyone because I wouldn't want to be seen as hindering an ongoing work-place investigation. I left that meeting and had a full panic attack in my car in front of my children. After I had done everything, they had asked of me and everything I could to try and help. Having been told from the beginning that I was in a failing department. Countless hours away from my children preparing lessons, I was thanked by having my integrity questioned. I also lost my friend Holly and could no longer speak to her.

During Spring break, I decided to start applying to other places as I no longer felt safe in such a toxic environment. After coming back from Spring break, I was never talked to about this meeting again, in fact, I was given very little communication from the School Director, the Enrollment Counselor, or the H.R. Rep ever again about math and my job; however, I have had several students come and tell me that I have been a favorite topic in the office and around the school. Students have overheard the ladies at the front office gossip about me; I have heard that The Business Manager, who has a reputation for being biased against women, has said to several people that I am over emotional and can't handle the job; and that the business office where the H.R. works, has been overheard talking about me and saying terrible things. My response was always, what others say about me is none of my business. I never asked any of my students what was said and encouraged them not to pay attention to that stuff. But this did hurt me. This toxic environment reaches all the way to the students.

Since Spring Break, I pretty much just kept to myself in fear of talking to anyone. I have spoken to the Teaching Coach a few times about how I felt things were mishandled and about leaving Vista. She was receptive and understanding. I have had short, all superficial interactions with the School Director. When I become very nervous, I say random things. He makes me nervous, scared, and on edge. Now I know many of those comments are rumors and gossip, but this is the "professional" environment that the School Director has created. An environment of fear, gossip, toxicity, secrecy, and unprofessionalism.

My test scores weren't great this year, but they were far better than expected. I was very proud of my students, and the vast majority of my students had a 20 to 30 point increase from their test scores the previous year. The math department and Administration have chosen a new curriculum for next year, and I feel that at least all of this was for a positive change.

The best example of the type of support the School Director gave me was during the 10 x's fair. This is where students take an object, measure it, multiply it by 10, and then build a replica using the new dimensions. The students brought in some amazing projects! I was so proud of their hard work and creativity. It was a huge success, and I am so grateful for the support shown from my colleagues and other staff members. I was told I needed to schedule a time for the School Director to attend the fair. I was taken back, I have never heard of a principal having to schedule an appearance to support his students, especially when his office is 30 feet away. It was an all-day event and could have dropped by anytime. His scheduled time was after carpool, but I wasn't expecting the students to come and pick up their projects after school so quickly. When he came in, it was just me cleaning up and the SPED department practicing for the talent show. I was

struggling to put a table away. He said Well neat! Talked about how big the rubics cube was and left. This is the prime example of his support. His time is more valuable than the students, he made an appearance, didn't recognize I was struggling, and left me to clean up by myself with just my two little kids.

I was offered a job teaching at a school near my parents. Because this year has been so emotionally, mentally, and physically taxing, I feel I need my parents support more than ever. I am a single mom, and my children have never seen me as emotionally distraught as I have been going through this year.

I love my students. Even though this year was hard, I have received an overwhelming number of thank you notes, emails, and comments from my students and their parents about the job I have done. On the student news, students expressed how math was their favorite class! I hope I helped change the perception of math in a positive way. After the administration made me feel like a complete failure as an educator, I needed that.

In all honesty, I wanted to stay at Vista. My daughter thrived, and I feel selfish that because of the toxic work environment I am taking her away from a place she has blossomed in.

When the School Director heard I was thinking of leaving, he did say they will support me in my decision; however, when I mentioned to the Teaching Coach that I was leaning towards staying, she encouraged me to go saying she understands needing support from Family. I felt that I really didn't have a choice. It was made clear I made the right decision when the School waited until the last day of school to tell the last remaining math teacher in our department, Maree Berry, they would not be renewing her contract with no explanation. No professionalism. Any reason he could give her, he would also be at fault. He excused low test scores, they changed the curriculum, and they told her to teach the curriculum despite her constantly telling them it wasn't working. I was in those meetings. She now has very limited options to apply for another job as they were posted back in April.

Truth is, the math teachers wanted to make change, the Administration fought them on it, created a culture of mistrust from the beginning, and is trying to manipulate the narrative that the School Director is making positive changes. No! He made huge mistakes and has been working frantically to cover it up. There are so many incredible things about Vista and truly remarkable teachers and staff. My fear is that other departments will be targeted if this toxicity is allowed to continue to fester.

The New School Director came from a place where he was put on administrative leave and then resigned for similar complaints that I am making now. Why did the Vista School Board allow this bully to enter our school and then sit idly by as he chased away talented, loyal, hardworking, and beloved staff and teachers? I tell my students all the time to stand up for what is right. I couldn't sit back and say nothing.

Sincerely,
Shala Hunsaker